

cumbersome to locate a track by scrolling through hundreds of stored ones.

The iPod Mini, on the other hand, has a much larger screen, and its click wheel allows for accelerated scrolling through tracks. The select button is in the centre of the touch-sensitive click wheel, and you can access the menu and playback functions through this single control, without using your other hand. It is very intuitive and makes life on the go easier.

Performance

The earphones provided with the iPod Mini provide excellent sound output and do not distort even at the maximum volume. They reproduce all types of music quite well, and will not disappoint audiophiles.

The output from the earphones of the Creative MuVo2 players is pretty much similar: we found them quite comfortable, and you will not get a earache after using them for hours. However, where the Creative MuVo2 scores best is battery life.

The iPod Mini gave us 7.5 hours of continuous playtime, whereas both the MuVo2 4GB as well as the FM 5GB gave us more than double that—15.5 hours.

Conclusion

We had a hard time deciding the winner between the iPod Mini and the Creative MuVo2 FM 5GB. Apart from the additional storage capacity, the latter also offers an FM tuner and voice recording. Moreover, the battery life is amazing.

The iPod Mini, on the other hand, has much better build quality and is extremely easy to use, especially while browsing through loads of tracks. Ease of use ultimately won over, and the iPod Mini gets the Best Buy Gold award. If battery life is extremely important, go for the Creative MuVo2 FM.

Earphones add to the pleasure of listening to music. Make sure you get your comfort level right with them



Apple iPod Mini

HARD DRIVE BASED PORTABLE AUDIO PLAYERS

Not all of us are happy carrying around a few MB of our favourite audio tracks. Some of us have GBs of audio collections, and need to have them wherever we go. Hard drive-based MP3 players are ideal for such audiophiles. With mammoth storage capacities, these devices are, however, heavier than micro hard drive-based and flash-based audio players. We have three players featured here, one each from Apple, Creative and S-Media.

Features

All three contenders featured the same storage capacity—20GB. The S-Media Cocopod was the only device in this category to boast of an FM tuner, voice recording and Line-in recording capabilities. The iPod offers both USB 2.0 and FireWire interfaces, and can play AAC, MP3, MP3 VBR, Apple Lossless, WAV, AIFF and Audible file formats.

Both the Creative Zen Touch and the Cocopod feature only a USB2.0 interface and only support MP3, WMA and WAV formats.

Apart from features such as alarm, calendar, notes, contacts and games, the iPod also has a rating feature that allows you to rate songs on the go. Tracks that are rated higher are repeated more often while in shuffle mode.

Tracks for the iPod can also be purchased online from the iTunes Music Store. The special features of the Zen Touch include an alphabetical search function and customisable touch sensitivity, while the Cocopod boasts of a bookmark feature that lets you play back from where you left off. It also has a very handy memory slot supporting SD and MMC cards. This can be used to transfer data on to the device.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

The Cocopod sports a roller scroll wheel placed inside a thumb recess on the front panel that also doubles up as a select control. It is flanked by a butterfly shaped four-way key that



Score Board

Brand	Model	Basic Specifications	Score	Price (Rs)
Apacer	Audio Steno BP300	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, 43gms	43.56	4530
Apacer	Audio Steno AV220	128MB, 1 AAA, 41gms	44.77	2819
Apacer	Audio Steno AP510	128MB, 1 AA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 83gms	46.52	9062
BenQ	Joybee 110	128MB, Rechargeable, 26gm	48.97	9500
BenQ	Joybee 120	128MB, Rechargeable, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 24gms	52.10	10500
Creative	Nomad MuVo NX	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, 43gms	54.01	6299
Creative	MuVo Slim	128MB, Rechargeable, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 34gms	58.24	6999
Creative	Rhomba NX	128MB, 2 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 62gms	61.73	7399
Creative	MuVo TX	256MB, 1AAA, Voice Recording, 43gms	54.16	7899
DMS	MP301	256MB, Rechargeable, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 50gms.	57.28	6999
Ennyah	DIGISound II DS601	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 57gms	52.36	4250
MSI	MegaStick	256MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 40gms	50.22	10000
Orite	Music Cookie	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, 42gms	44.96	4950
Samsung	Digital Audio Player Yepp YP-60	256MB, Rechargeable, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 61gms	52.12	15995
Samsung	Digital Audio Player Yepp YP-55	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 61gm	51.97	10995
Samsung	Digital Audio Player Yepp YP-T5	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 35gm	56.28	10995
S-Media	Butterfly	128MB, Rechargeable, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 62gms	55.24	8055
Sony	Network Walkman	256MB, Rechargeable, 54gms	51.55	29990
Transcend	JetFlash	256MB, 1AAA, Voice Recording, 36	44.04	5000
Umax	Vega	128MB, 1 AAA, Voice Recording, FM tuner, FM recording, 70gms	47.69	7000
Umax	Draco	128MB, 1 AAA, 50gms	42.78	4900